

BIG PAYCHEQUES

Women are rising in rank, but pay gaps and underrepresentation at the top keep true parity still out of reach

BY MAMTA SHARMA



EARLY IN HER CAREER, Deepa Purushothaman was told by her supervisor she must choose: “I think I can get you a bigger raise or promote you early, but I don’t think I can do both right now because I have to distribute the wealth.” He asked her to take the weekend and decide which one she wanted.

Most women would have quietly accepted the menu handed to them. Purushothaman didn’t.

On Monday, she said, “I’m thankful but don’t know why I have to choose. The promotion is more important to me because it’s a sign of readiness, but having to do more work for the same money doesn’t sit well with me. I’d like both.”

She got both.

Two decades later, the menu hasn’t changed much.

“I’ve been fortunate not to personally face the gender pay gap, but many senior women do. Too often, as women, we accept the menu we’re offered, even when it doesn’t reflect what we truly want. Speaking up can inspire others to treat us with greater respect,” says Purushothaman, founder of re.write, a

3 **Internal narratives, confidence gaps, and motherhood penalties deepen pay disparities, even when women match or outperform men**

4 **Negotiation isn’t enough; women need visibility, sponsorship, and strategic advocacy to counter systemic and behavioural biases**

5 **True parity demands transparent pay structures, equity audits, unbiased evaluations, and cultural accountability from leadership**